

Core game design - Wizard Yan's Diary: The Remembrance Alchemy

Core player experience

The player explores the world as Rob, a spirit of a legendary otter Robak, summoned by alchemist Yan to help him learn alchemy. The player encounters new materials and memories, conducts experiments with alchemy alongside Yan, and gradually develops their understanding of alchemy, Rob's story, and their relationship with Yan.

Core gameplay structure – learning cycles

The game is structured around a series of player-driven learning cycles. Rather than following a fixed sequence of activities, the player can explore, experiment, investigate memories, interact with Yan, place objects around the tower, and pursue discoveries in different orders. These activities gradually expand the list of available ingredients, number of alchemical stations, improve the cauldron and build the player's understanding of alchemy and Rob's own history. Each cycle converges on an alchemy examination, where the game tests whether the player understands the principles that they have encountered, rather than whether they have memorized recipes.

Player activities

1. Exploration – traversing the tower in search of secrets, visiting a nearby town, forest and lake to acquire ingredients. This is also the primary way of obtaining memories from Rob's past life; a visit to the lake can trigger a memory of travelling with Jan.
2. Alchemy experimentation – interacting with various alchemical stations (cauldron, mortar, alembic, ...) to discover ingredients' properties, create new ingredients, upgrade stations (i.e. more slots, information, QoL features), make objects that can be placed around the tower, and deepen the understanding of alchemy.
3. Memory investigation – each unlocked memory is stored in the player's inventory. These should not be treated as the source of truth, but rather beliefs to be questioned, like "Yan said I'm just a dead animal". Combining two memories can result in a new, stronger memory, or can create a contradiction to be resolved through conversations. Some assumptions about alchemy are also in the form of memories.
4. Interacting with Yan – dialogue based. Rob can discuss various topics with Yan, ranging from alchemy, history, philosophy, their relationship, to small-talk. The

player can also present a memory to figure out a contradiction or to understand what Yan meant with a particular line.

5. Placing objects around the tower – I want the player to feel like the tower is a new home for Rob, so to create an attachment they can place some objects that they have found or crafted together with Yan – like the first brewed potion, a poster, a potted plant, a bed, etc. Some of these are purely decorative, while others provide unlocks (i.e. soundtrack variant).
6. Alchemic examination – at any time the player can take on an alchemic examination, which tests the player's understanding of alchemy system. Failing a test has no negative consequences and the player can retake it whenever they are ready. Passing the examination advances the game into a new cycle with new questions, systems and discoveries.

Progression

Player's knowledge

Over the course of the game the player will have to learn the mechanics behind alchemy – elemental properties of ingredients, how they change through various stations (i.e. what does the mortar do?), the rules of each station, how recipes work.

Rob's and Robak's memories

As the game progresses, Rob acquires more memories about his past life (Robak), which slowly fill in the gaps in understanding his story and what it would mean to be resurrected. At the same time, he creates new memories through interacting with Yan and exploring the world. Some memories are blurry because of the resurrection spell, it's up to player to construct their own version of the story.

Relationship progression

At the start of the game, Yan believes that Rob is just a familiar spirit. Soon they develop a student/teacher relationship, which blooms into friendship. As they both learn the story of Robak and Jan, Yan realizes that Rob has lived a life that was abruptly taken away from him. He questions whether it is right to resurrect Robak, and what their friendship means.

World progression

The game narrative is reflected in the passing of seasons. Poland experiences six distinct natural seasons: early spring, true spring, summer, golden autumn, deep autumn and winter. The game starts in golden autumn and ends next golden autumn. Passing an alchemical examination advances the season to the next one. It also unlocks new locations with memories and ingredients.

Alchemy progression

When the game starts, the player can acquire only a handful of ingredients. The only available alchemical station is the cauldron. Through exploration and alchemy, they will unlock more potent ingredients. Passing an examination unlocks new alchemical stations, like mortar and alembic, which can be used to further process ingredients.

Systems relationships

Exploration unlocks new ingredients for **alchemy** and memories for **investigation**.

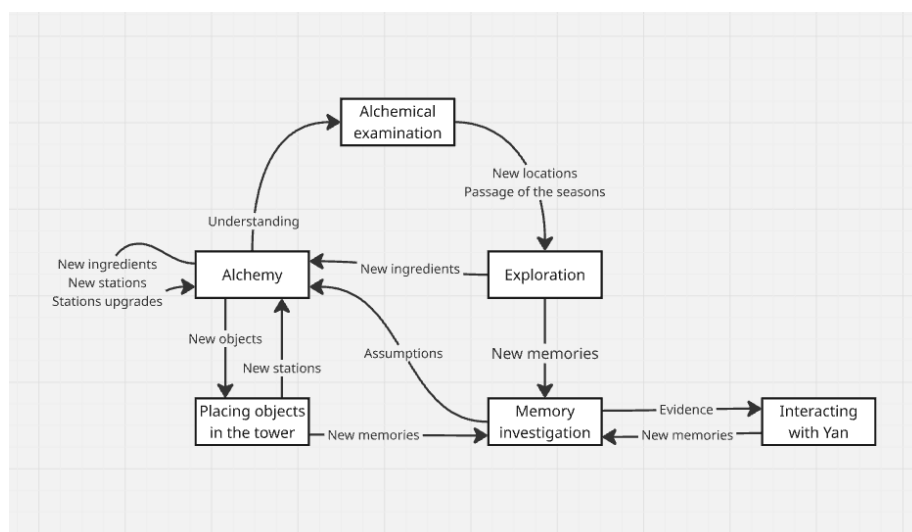
Alchemy provides a **self-feeding** loop for discovering new ingredients and upgrading stations. It also raises understanding of the alchemy systems for **examination**. Moreover, objects crafted in alchemy can be **placed in the tower**.

Memory investigation is the primary system for learning the backstory of Rob. Some assumptions about **alchemy** are in the form of memories. Memories can also be used while **interacting with Yan**.

Interacting with Yan creates **memories** about Rob's current and previous life as well as **alchemy**.

Placing objects in the tower unlocks some new stations for **alchemy**. Some objects can be used to create new **memories** about Rob's current life, i.e. placing a pile of stones, a bell collar, otter's bed.

Passing an **alchemical examination** unlocks more locations for **exploration**, and in some cases new stations for **alchemy**. It is also the only way to progress the story.



Player's journey

The story is structured in seven acts, themed around the six seasons of Poland. The game starts and ends in the golden autumn, giving it a circular structure. The two main goals are: learning who Rob is and mastering alchemy. Here, I'm focusing on the story part, since alchemy mechanics are still being conceptualized. I'm mentioning only the key events, the entire story will be a subject of another document.

The distinction between Rob and Robak and Yan and Jan is very important. Rob is the familiar spirit summoned by alchemist Yan, while Robak was a legendary otter owned by Jan Chryzostom Pasek, a polish sarmate. Yan and Jan are different people, though the story implies otherwise. Rob has Robak's memories, but whether they are the same creature is a philosophical question to be answered by the player at the end of the game.

Act I – Golden Autumn

The player arrives in a strange world as an otter-shaped spirit, tasked with helping a young alchemist. Together they conduct first alchemical experiments and explore nearby locations. Rob starts remembering bits and pieces, but attributes them to being just a random noise. Rob and Yan start a student/teacher relationship.

The alchemy workshop offers just a handful of ingredients and cauldron for alchemy. The player learns that recipes are not about ingredients, but their properties.

Act II – Deep Autumn

The player learns that Rob isn't just a familiar spirit but was living a life as an otter prior to being summoned. First memories of Rob with Jan resurface. Rob is angry at Yan for stealing him from his previous life and wants to return to Jan.

After the first examination, ingredient analysis becomes available. New location is unlocked, the river, which provides new ingredients and memories of playing in the river.

Act III – Winter

The player discovers a memory of Robak being held captive (bell collar created through alchemy). They start questioning whether Robak's life was as good as they initially imagined. Rob and Yan's relationship slowly changes into friendship. Meanwhile, the tower is slowly filled with Rob's things, becoming his new home.

Throughout this act the player realizes that alchemy is a map, rather than a set of recipes. Yan and Rob create a map of alchemy and start charting areas that define the final result of an experiment.

Act IV – Early Spring

Rob finally remembers meeting Jan in a forest, along with happy memories of travelling together as companions. He starts questioning if he's Rob or Robak. Yan starts to believe that he might be Jan, because in Rob's memories Jan has Yan's face.

The player unlocks the mortar. Mortar introduces a new level of a map with inaccessible areas, that must be reached through combination of ground and fresh ingredients. Previous locations now have new ingredients and memories (spring).

Act V – True Spring

In this act the player learns that Robak was stolen from Jan by the king and held captive in his manor. The story culminates in Robak getting rid of bell collar and escaping into nearby woods. Rob suspects that he was summoned by Yan moments before reaching Jan. Yan blames himself for allowing Robak to be stolen.

The player unlocks furnace, which introduces fuel mechanics. Cauldron gains fuel slot, which allows for further exploration of map of alchemy. Town location is unlocked, which provides new dialogue options and memories.

Act VI – Summer

Rob remembers his death, which occurred while he was escaping from the manor. His last memory is of Jan's true face in tears, bending over dying Robak. Yan realizes that he's not Jan and starts wondering if resurrecting Robak is the right choice in the end.

Another level of mortar is unlocked, which allows the player to explore the final level of alchemy map, where the Remembrance alchemy resides. Already unlocked locations now provide new ingredients and memories (summer).

Act VII – Golden Autumn

The player has learned the entire back story of Rob. Meanwhile Rob has grown attached to Yan and the tower, which is his new home. Now the player must make a choice: are they Robak or Rob? Or both? Do they want to be resurrected? This act focuses on the current relationship between Rob and Yan, shaped by memories they made along the journey.

Remembrance alchemy is ready to be cast. The player realizes that there are multiple regions that result in resurrection – the ending is mechanically driven. If the player mastered alchemy, they can pick their own ending.

Open design questions

1. How much freedom should alchemy provide?
2. How much of the game is exploration vs experimentation?
3. Which form of alchemical examination would be the most coherent with the story (knowledge test, live experimentation, presenting memories)?
4. How much should Rob's memories be fallible?
5. Should the player be able to convince Yan that he is Jan?